

VISION and precision

Meet the midfield architects and attacking stars who promise to light up the 2026 World Cup.

SPAIN

Age - 23

Club - Barcelona

NT Appearances - 40

Goals - 5

Assists - 4

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Pedri has long been dubbed the successor to greats Andres Iniesta and Xavi Hernández in Spain's midfield. And, over the years, he has substantiated those claims.

But Iniesta and Xavi are widely regarded as defining figures of Spain's dominance from 2008 to 2012, and their exploits in major tournaments have stood out, while Pedri is yet to have his watershed moment.

His best international campaign, at the age of 18, ended in heartbreak as Italy knocked Spain out in the Euro 2020 semifinals, and the World Cup in Qatar wrapped up even earlier at the hands of Morocco.

While Spain secured a fourth European title in 2024, Pedri's contributions ended in the eighth minute of the quarterfinal against Germany after he picked up a knee injury.

So, with the nation looking to enter another era of dominance, the World Cup will be Pedri's time to make his mark. And his performances over the last two seasons with Barcelona — where he won five titles — have seen him evolve from a lung-bursting midfielder into a midfield general.

His two goals and 12 assists in 43 appearances this season may not sound remarkable but, at just 23, he regularly wears the captain's armband for Barca and has shaped into a utility man who can play his team out of pressure and split oppositions open while also fulfilling defensive duties.

If he can remain fit, Pedri will be the crucial but silent commander behind Spain's quest for a second World Cup triumph.

Pedri

